RUNNING FITNESS SESSION CONTENT

WELCOME

Welcome to this British Athletics - Leadership in Running Fitness Course – Running Fitness Session Content

OBJECTIVES

By the end of this module, you should be able to understand:

- How to undertake pre-session checks, HOW 2 safety key principles and HOW 2 organisation points
- How to deliver a RAMP based warm up
- What fundamental movements are and how to include them in your session activity
- About endurance running technique
- About HOW 2 Instruction & Explanation of key principles and HOW 2 Demonstration key points
- The purpose of a cool down, what to include, how to correctly perform stretches and adapt them to make suitable for all.

PRE-SESSION CHECKS

Let's take a look at safety considerations and the importance of dynamic risk assessment.

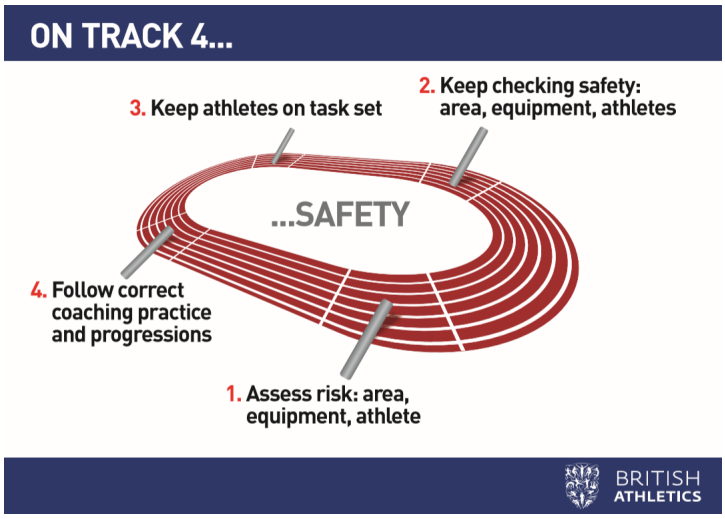
Did you know that as a leader you should be making visual safety checks during your running sessions? You should be checking:

- The facilities and equipment
- That runners are appropriately dressed
- The runners injury status and any impairments
- The route and conditions
- The number of runners in the group

Why don't we take a look at safety in a bit more detail.

HOW2 SAFETY KEY PRINCIPLES

Why don't we take a look at this HOW2 SAFETY card?



We'd like you to watch this warm up video and afterwards you'll have some questions to answer.

Have a think about the video you watched and then use this session to answer the questions:

- What hazards did the leader identify in the area, with the athletes and the equipment? How were they minimised?
- What did the leader do during the session to ensure safety was maintained?
- What did the leader do to ensure athletes stayed on task?
- What did the leader do to ensure the content and progressions were appropriate to the ability of the individuals and the group?

Well done. Let's see how your answers compares with our observations.

In the video, they had set out a large-coned area in a park, away from footpath. In the small space warm up, the leader identified the area was near a road and so had used small space safely away from the traffic and had the runners spaced out around the edge.

The leader was running in the opposite direction to the runners so he could see them all easily. In the small space warm up, the leader ran up and down between the runners.

The leader changed the activity frequently, to keep the runners on task.

The leader followed the principles of a warm-up.

Why don't we have a look at this HOW2 ORGANISATION card?

Have a think about the video you watched and then use this session to answer questions regarding Organisation. Click on the video above to view again.

- How did both leaders manage the equipment and the space?
- What did the leaders do to ensure the activities were safe?
- How did the leaders group the runners?
- How did the group size contribute to the intensity and the involvement of the activity?

Let's see how your answers compare with our observations.

The leader set out the cones in a large space to give the runners room. In the small space, the leader planned activities to warm the runner's up without having to move around.

In both warm-ups the leader moved around to ensure runners were safe.

At the end of the warm-up, the leader sent the runners off into groups by ability for the main session.

You could see by the difference in both warm-ups that space and group size dictated the type and intensity of activity used by the leader to warm the group up.

RAMP BASED WARM UP

It's important that fundamental movements are incorporated into the warm-up. It's advisable to use RAMP warm-ups, because it's proven to be the most effective runner warm up and stands for:

Raise - heart rate, temperature, blood flow, muscle elasticity and neural activation

Activate - the muscles to prepare for the main session

Mobilise - the joints and tendons using movement patterns to be used during the main session

Potentiate - increase the stress and intensity, to prepare body and mind for session.

We are now going to look at a video of these principles being applied in a warm up.

Ramp Warm up

Thinking back to the warm-up video, where did you see these principles applied?

Here are some of the examples shown in the video and also other examples that you can include depending on the stage and experience of the athlete.

Hopefully, you have learnt from the video about the importance of keeping the warm-up simple and progressive, by including:

- Walking, jogging, skipping, side steps, backwards running, hopscotch
- Walking lunges, scoops, sumo squats, round the clock lunges, spider man walks, leg balance warriors
- High knee runs, butt kick runs, high skips, strides
- Short runs:
    - 7 out of 10 effort
    - 8 out of 10 effort
    - 9 out of 10 effort.

Warm-ups should increase in intensity as you work through to move the runner seamlessly into their main session.

For children some of these warm-up activities can be done in the form of a game like 'Dishes and Domes' or 'Cat and Mouse'.

WARM UP FUNDAMENTALS

Let's take a closer look at how you can include fundamental movements in your warm-ups and their safety technical points.

Lunge

- Feet approximately hip width apart in the split squat position and hands on hips
- Lunge position with one leg forward (hip and knee joints flexed at approximately 90°). The other leg behind the midline of the body (knee underneath hip)
- Maintain vertical alignment of trunk throughout.

Squat

- Equal stance on both legs and feet at shoulder width apart
- Descend into squat (flex at hip, knee and ankle) with weight distributed equally between both feet
- Ensure head is neutral, chest up and straight back.

Push (push up)

- Set shoulder blades down and back and support the weight on hands and feet
- Lower the chest to the floor and return

- Trunk remains fixed and straight at all times.

Brace (front brace)

- Support arms are placed under shoulders
- Feet are just inside shoulder width
- Body straight and in-line.

Take off (standing jumps)

- Equal stance on both legs
- Triple extension at ankle, knee and hip (straight leg during and after take off)
- Remain long and tall in the air.

Landing (jumps)

- Bend at the hip, knee and ankle (triple flexion)
- Equal stance on both legs
- On landing, trunk parallel to shins.

WARM UP PURPOSE TASK

We'd now like you to complete a task to get you thinking about what the purpose of a warm-up is. We'd like you to answer the following questions, by thinking about the warm-up video you watched.

- What is the purpose of doing a warm-up?
- What did the tutor do:
  - to raise heart rates?
  - to activate and mobilise the muscles and joints?
  - to get athletes ready for higher intensity work?

Well done. Let's see how your answers compares with ours.

- The purpose of a warm-up is to prepare body and mind for the main session.
- The tutor raised heart rates through a series of brisk walking and jogging.
- The tutor activated and mobilised the athletes muscles and joints by using movements, such as side stepping and arm swings.
- The tutor prepared the athletes for higher intensity work by high knees and butt kicks (the session to follow was an out and back loop at 6 out of 10 effort).

During any warm-ups it's important to consider safety within the progressions, to ensure they are appropriate for the individuals ability levels. Make use of RAMP warms up because they are the most effective for athletes.

WHAT2 ENDURANCE RUNNING TECHNIQUE AND HOW 2 ORGANISATION

Why don't we take a look at endurance technique? But before we do lets take a look at balance and coordination and how they are important in developing effective and efficient running technique.

HIGH KNEE STOP VIDEO
COORDINATION THROWING VIDEO

Agility, balance and coordination are important for developing good running technique by:

- coordinating arms and legs when running
- coordinating body parts when developing strength or flexibility in other activities which support the development of running robustness
- being stable and balanced when foot is in contact with the ground to minimise energy leakage

Did you know that agility is achieved by being balanced and coordinated at speed?

The technical points for endurance running are:

- Tall posture with high hips
- Relaxed shoulders with efficient backwards driving arm action (elbow at approx. 90o)
- Minimal rotation of the trunk
- Rhythm guides optimal speed and efficiency
- Foot lands naturally underneath the centre of mass, moving down and backwards
- Run with toe up action.

It's important that you have an awareness and understanding of the endurance running technique. This will be covered in more detail during your practical day but please watch this video as an introduction.

This video includes various running tips about endurance racing. Please take notes.

ENDURANCE RUNNING TECHNIQUE VIDEO

PURPOSE OF COOL DOWN

Let's have a look at what the purpose of a cool down is.

- It accelerates recovery and prevents muscle soreness
- It reduces heart, respiration rate and body temperature
- It provides a calm mind
- It provides opportunity to reflect on a session

To summarise, a cool down is to slowly return the body to the pre-exercise state. If exercise ends abruptly, blood pressure may drop, which could cause dizziness or fainting.

Let's take a look at this cool down video, so we can see what a cool down should consist of.

COOL DOWN VIDEO

You'll see from the video that the runners were reducing the intensity of the workout, in order to return their bodies to a 'pre-exercise' state. They were also doing various stretches, for 10-15 seconds each, as this a crucial part of a cool down. We'll next take a look at what to include in a cool down.

WHAT TO INCLUDE IN COOL DOWN

So what should be included in a cool down? Select if you think the following suggestions are true or false.

- Gentle jogging and walking
- Static stretches of all the major muscle groups
- Lunges, squats and push ups
- Hold each stretch for 10-15 seconds
- Discussion about the session

Here are the correct answers.

- Gentle jogging and walking
- Static stretches of all the major muscle groups
- Hold each stretch for 10-15 seconds
- Discussion about the session

Now we know what to include in a cool down, let's take a look at stretching in more detail.

COOL DOWN STRETCHING

Stretching is a crucial part of a cool down because it can help reduce lactic acid build-up and therefore reduces the chances of muscle cramps and stiffness.

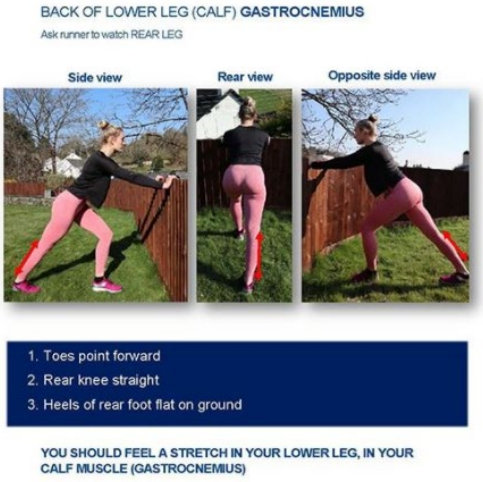
There are ten cool down stretches that we would like you to learn about. Two of these we will cover now and the others you can view in the resources.

Stretching best practices.

Back of lower Leg (Calf) Gastrocnemius

Back of lower Leg (Calf) Soleus Video

- Back of lower calf stretch card



- Side of trunk stretch card & Video

Further stretch cards are available in the resource section and further videos in MY LEARNING.

HOW-2 INSTRUCTION & EXPLANATION/HOW-2 DEMONSTRATION

We are now going to look at a video of a cool down and your task is to see if you can see where you can identify the cool down principles and top tips for giving instructions and a demonstration.

COOL DOWN VIDEO

Have a think about the video you watched and then use this session to answer the questions regarding Instruction and Explanation:

- What helped the leader to provide quick and clear instructions at the beginning of the activity?
- How did the leader gain the attention of the runners?
- What made the instructions simple?
- What did the leader do to check the runners understanding?

Let's see how your answers compare with our observations.

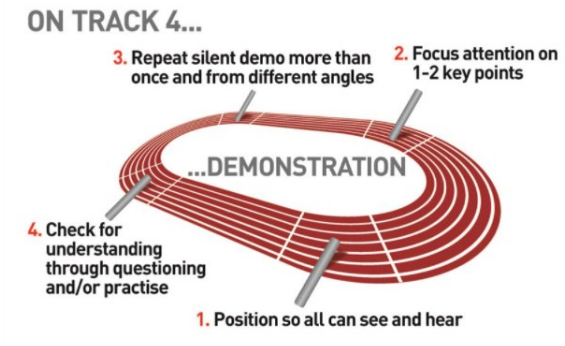
The leader had planned what they were going to say and do prior to speaking with the runners.

The leader positioned themselves so that the sun was behind the group (to limit any distractions) and asked the runners to position themselves so that they could all see and hear the leader.

Only a few (2 or 3) instructions were given at the beginning that enabled the runners to get active quickly.

The leader used 'open' questions (questions that require more than a 'yes' or 'no' answer) to check for understanding with the group of runners.

Reflecting on the video you have just watched, and now thinking about the Demonstrations, answer the following questions. Use the Demonstration HOW 2 Card to help.



- Where did the leader position themselves so that the runners could see and hear them?
- How many points of attention did the leader give and can you recall what they were?
- How many times did the leader demonstrate each activity and from which angles? What helped the runners maintain their focus whilst observing the demonstration?
- What did the leader do to check for understanding?

Let's see how your answers compare with our observations:

The leader was positioned in front of the group, with the sun behind the runners and limited distractions behind the leader.

For each demonstration there were 2 or 3 points to focus on. For the trunk strength the runners were asked to identify an upright trunk and the arm placed close to the ear.

The leader did at least 2 demonstrations from the side and then from the front (towards the runners) or from the back (facing away from the runners).
The leader demonstrated silently so the focus was on the action rather than what was being said.

The leader asked the runners what they had observed and then asked them to have a go, and the leader observed them practising.

You should also consider discussing these HOW 2 skills with your CiRF/Level 2 Coach and reviewing how well you apply them in your own sessions.

CONGRATULATIONS

Congratulations! You have now finished this British Athletics - Leadership in Running Fitness Course – Running Fitness Session.

You should now be able to understand:

- About the pre-session checks, HOW 2 safety key principles and HOW 2 organisation points
- How to deliver a RAMP based warm up
- What fundamental movements are and how to include them in your session activity
- About endurance running technique
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Thank you and goodbye.